CLASS 4 HANDOUT

Wants and Needs (Self Care)

Finding Peace Within

What are they?

*Adapted from **Facing Codependence** by Pia Mellody, Andrea Miller, & J. Keith Miller*

- Needs are defined as the basic needs that are required to survive
  - All people have dependency needs
  - Adults are responsible for knowing how to address each need
  - Some needs like physical nurturing or emotional nurturing can only be met through interaction with another person
- Wants are the preferences, items or goals we look to include in our life
  - Some wants are large and shape many life choices and direction
    - "I want to be married to this person"
    - "I want to have a child"
    - "I want to be a doctor"
  - Some wants are small and make up a few choices and express our preference
    - "I want Mexican food tonight"
    - "I want to sit down"
- Wants and needs become apparent as we bring our Reality and Boundaries into Relationships

What is the issue?

- People with complex trauma have difficulty meeting their own wants and needs
- This can become evident in some different ways
  - Too Dependent
    - I am aware of my needs and wants, but I expect other people to take care of them for me.
  - Anti Dependent
    - I am aware of my needs and wants, but I am unwilling to accept help meeting them from anyone else.
  - Wantless and Needless
    - I am not aware of my needs and wants
    - I get my wants and needs confused

Where these patterns come from

*Adapted from **Facing Codependence** by Pia Mellody, Andrea Miller, & J. Keith Miller*

- Too dependent
  - Our parents took care of everything instead of teaching us to meet our own needs
- Antidependent
  - We were attacked for having and expressing needs and wants
- Needless and wantless
  - Our needs and wants were ignored or neglected, so we never learned to name them
- Confusing needs and wants
  - We got everything we wanted but little of what we needed, like physical and emotional nurturing

Why asking feels selfish

- When we feel a need or want, shame flares up
  - It started in childhood, when expressing a need or want was met with abuse or neglect
  - We may have forgotten the memory, but the feeling remains
- We feel selfish for needing or wanting something, however legitimate it is
- Recovery is interdependence
  - Noticing our needs and wants, meeting what we can ourselves, and asking for help without shame or guilt

Exercise: Which pattern is mine?

- [ ] Too dependent: I know my needs and wants, but I expect others to take care of them
- [ ] Antidependent: I know my needs and wants, but I won't accept help meeting them
- [ ] Needless and wantless: I'm not aware of my needs and wants
- [ ] Confusing needs and wants: I get what I want, but I don't know what I need

1. How were needs and wants handled in the home I grew up in?

2. Where do I see that pattern in my life now?

What does it look like?

- Sharing our Reality and Boundaries in a relationship allows us to connect with the other person, which is a innate need we all have
- There are three ways that sharing of our Reality and Boundaries can look
  - Interdependent
    - Two overlapping circles
      - Each circle has portions that are seperate
      - Each circle has portions that are overlapping
    - Allows both people to have their own sense of self (Reality)
    - Allows both people to understand they are seperate from the other (Boundaries)
    - Allows both people to share their choosen wants and needs with another (Connection)
  - Anti-Dependent
    - Two seperate circles
      - Each circle is completely seperate
    - Allows both people to have their own sense of self (Reality)
    - Allows both people to understand they are seperate from the other (Boundaries)
    - Does not allow both people to share their choosen wants and needs with another (Connection)
  - Enmeshed
    - One oval
      - There is no clear definition of where one circle stops and another begins
    - Does not allow both people to have their own sense of self (Reality)
    - Does not allow both people to understand they are seperate from the other (Boundaries)
    - Does not allow both people to share their choosen wants and needs with another (Connection)

Skills for developing our Wants and Needs

- Work on your vulnerability
  - Decide if the person is safe
  - Decide what wants and needs you are willing to share with them
  - Be willing to feel the fear when sharing those wants and needs you choose to share
  - Work on trusting yourself to handle what the other person does with your shared reality

- Work on independence
  - Decide what wants and needs you feel you are responsible for meeting
  - Ask for help identifying what items you can meet yourself
  - Start taking steps to meet those wants and needs yourself

- Work on understanding your wants and needs
  - Work on developing your Reality and Boundaries
    - This will naturally start to develop your sense of your own wants and needs
  - Practice deciding what your wants are in low pressure situations
  - Begin to express the wants and needs you are willing to share
  - Understand the other person may not be used to hearing your wants and needs

Exercise: Asking for help

1. One need I have that takes another person to meet (for example: time, attention, direction, or physical comfort):

2. A safe person I could ask:

3. The words I would use ("Would you be willing to…?"):

Take-home: The wants experiment

*From **Breaking Free** by Pia Mellody & Andrea Wells Miller*

If you're not sure what you want, that's normal. We learn our wants by guessing at something, getting it, and finding out whether we really wanted it. Some guesses will turn out to be things you don't want, and that is part of the process.

1. Guess at three small wants and write them below.
2. This week, get one or more of them for yourself.
3. Mark whether it brought you joy.

A want I'm guessing at	Did I get it?	Did it bring me joy? (yes / no)

Group Questions

Check-in first Which boundary statement did you practice? How did it feel to say it, or even just think it?

Answer from whichever level fits where you are tonight. It's fine to stay in Start.

Start

JUST STARTING OUT

1. What is one thing you need and one thing you want right now?

2. What is one small thing that helps you feel cared for?

Go deeper

APPLY TONIGHT'S IDEAS

3. Which pattern do you recognize most in yourself: too dependent, anti-dependent, or needless and wantless? What does it look like in your day-to-day?

4. When someone offers to help you, what is your gut reaction? Where do you think that came from?

Stretch

FOR A BIGGER CHALLENGE

5. When you notice a need or want, what does the “that’s selfish” voice say? Whose voice does it sound like?

6. What is one need you could let a safe person help meet this week, and what makes asking hard for you?